

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

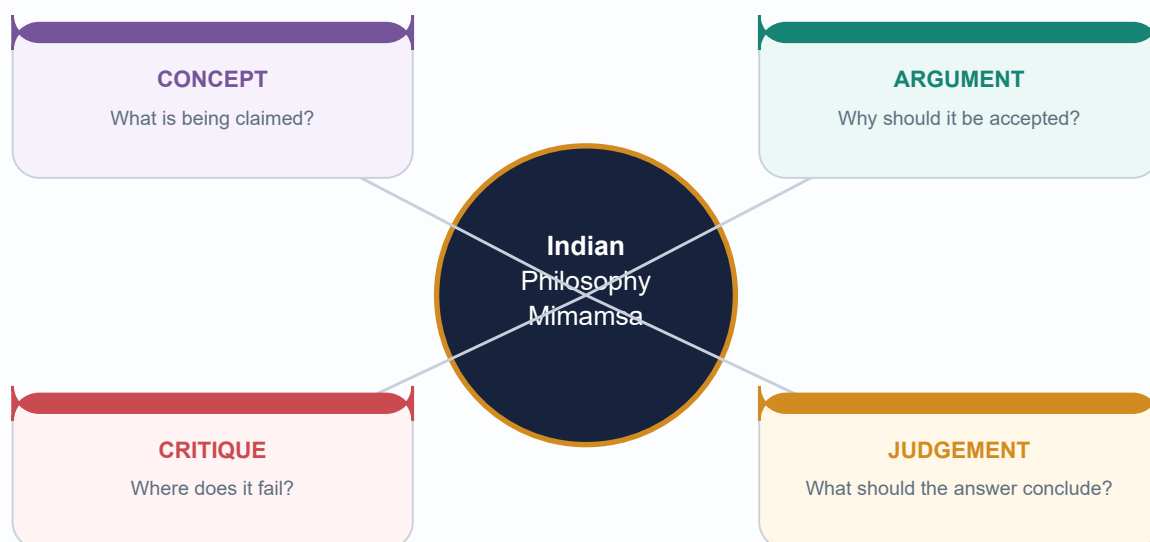
Indian Philosophy: Mimamsa

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Theory of Knowledge.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Mimamsa chapter (local PDF pp. 248-269); C. D. Sharma, Purva-Mimamsa chapter (printed pp. 199-226); Radhakrishnan, Indian Philosophy Vol. II, Purva-Mimamsa chapter. Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: Knowledge in Defence of Dharma

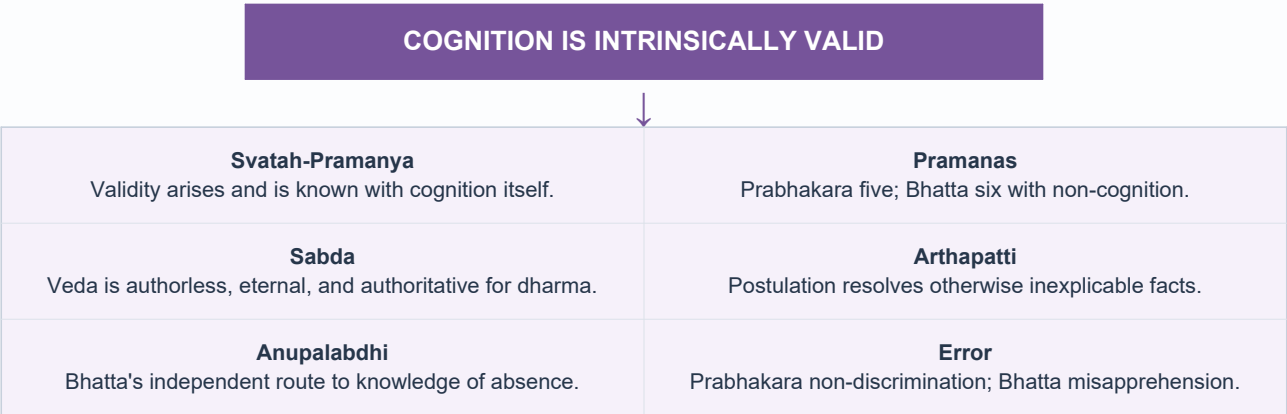
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

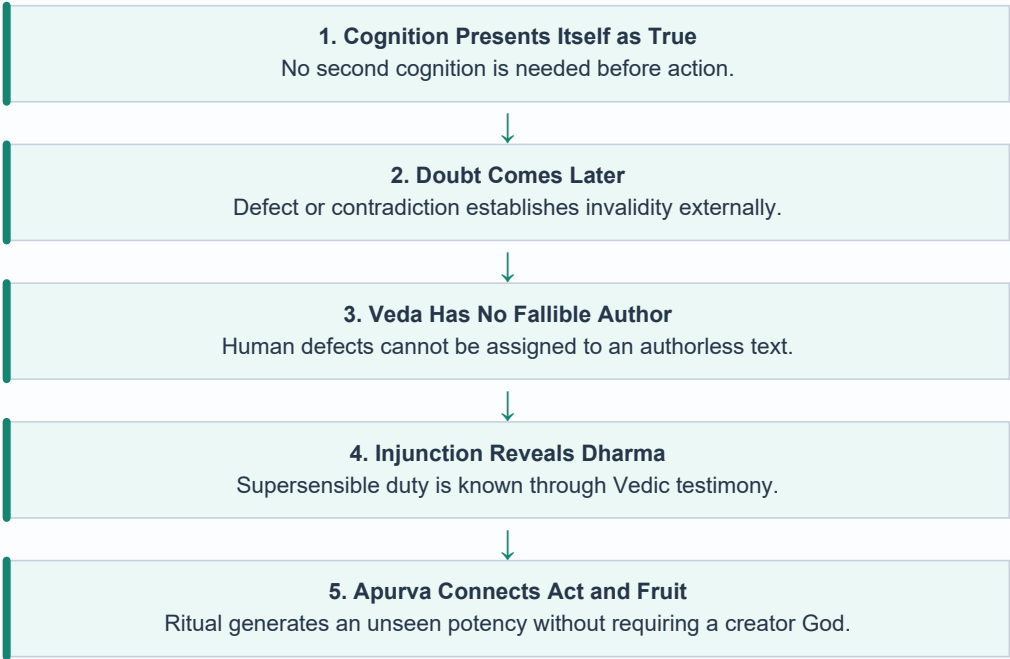
Mimamsa epistemology is organized around the authority of Vedic injunction. Cognition is prima facie valid, verbal testimony reaches supersensible dharma, and distinct pramanas explain postulation and absence.

Two sub-schools must be kept distinct: Prabhakara accepts five pramanas; Bhatta accepts six by adding anupalabdhi. They also differ on error, absence, word-meaning, sentence-meaning, and cognition of cognition.

MIMAMSA MASTER MAP



WHY EPISTEMOLOGY SUPPORTS VEDIC AUTHORITY



MEMORY HOOK

SELF-VALID KNOWLEDGE + AUTHORLESS WORD + UNSEEN DUTY = MIMAMSA EPISTEMOLOGY.

CONCEPT LINKS

Mimamsa Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Svatah-pramanya	Nyaya paratah-pramanya	Recurring validity debate.
Arthapatti	Nyaya inference	Independent postulation versus reducibility.
Anupalabdhi	Vaisesika abhava	Means of knowing absence versus category of absence.
Apauruseya Veda	Nyaya divine author	Competing explanations of scripture.

MAINS ANGLE

Mimamsa builds an economical presumption of truth, but its deepest aim is practical knowledge of dharma.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 18; organize answers around validity, pramanas, verbal knowledge, and error.

HIGH

Technical Terms and Pramana Structure

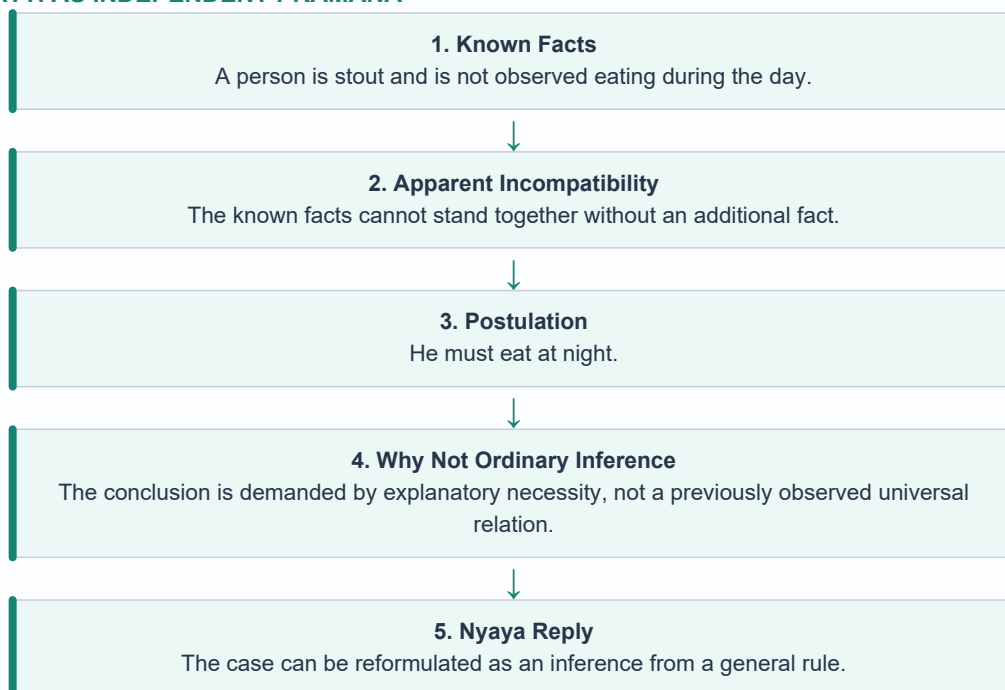
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Mimamsa expands the standard list of pramanas to capture knowledge not reducible to perception or inference. The Bhatta-Prabhakara divide is a major UPSC axis.

KEY DATA

Term	Bhatta / Prabhakara Position	Example or Use
Pratyaksa	Both accept perception.	Immediate cognition through sense contact.
Anumana	Both accept inference.	Fire from smoke.
Upamana	Both accept comparison, with analysis differing from Nyaya.	Knowing an unfamiliar object through similarity.
Sabda	Both accept verbal testimony; Veda has supreme authority.	Knowledge of dharma.
Arthapatti	Both accept as independent postulation.	A person is stout, does not eat by day; postulate night eating.
Anupalabdhi	Bhatta accepts; Prabhakara rejects as separate.	Knowing absence of a pot through non-apprehension.
Svatah-pramanya	Both defend intrinsic validity.	Cognition guides action before external verification.
Paratah-apramanya	Invalidity is established by external defect or contradiction.	Later correction reveals error.
Apurva	Unseen potency generated by ritual action.	Connects present sacrifice with future fruit.

ARTHAPATTI AS INDEPENDENT PRAMANA**STATIC THEORY**

- **Pramana plurality:** each source has a distinctive causal route and object-domain.
- **Arthapatti:** explanatory postulation, not arbitrary hypothesis.
- **Anupalabdhi:** Bhatta argues that qualified non-perception directly reveals absence where perception would otherwise occur.
- **Prabhakara alternative:** absence is handled without a separate pramana, often through the positive cognition of the locus.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Prabhakara accepts five pramanas; Bhatta accepts six.
2. Both reject memory as pramana because it does not reveal a previously unknown object.
3. Sabda is especially necessary for dharma, which is not available to ordinary perception.

MAINS ANGLE

The independence of arthapatti and anupalabdhi depends on whether their conclusions require unique cognitive mechanisms.

STUDY LINK

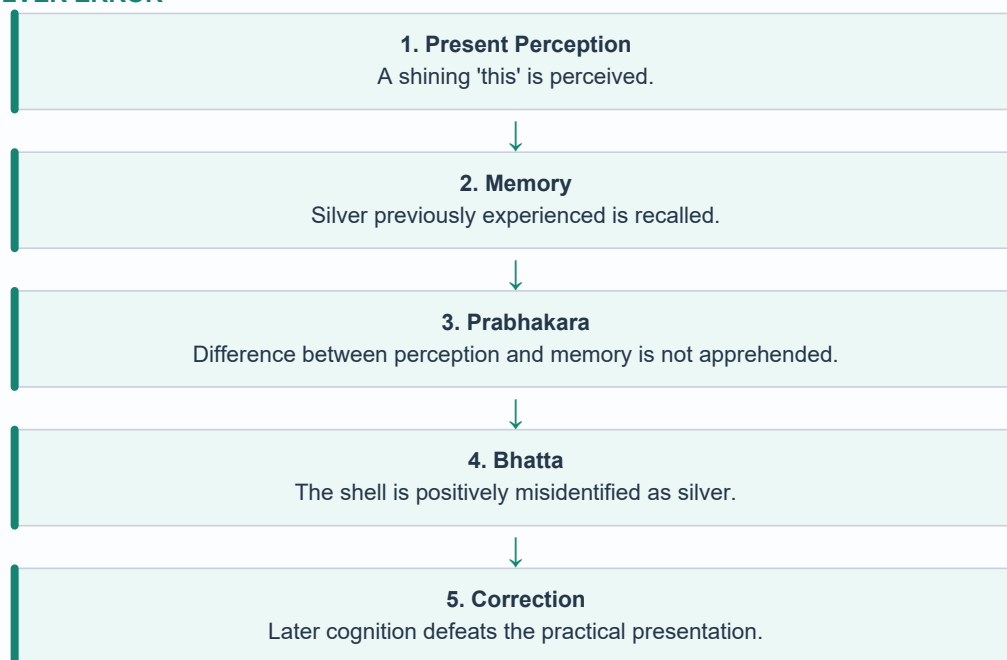
Use the applied candidate example for arthapatti versus Nyaya inference.

HIGH**Validity, Cognition of Cognition, Error, and Language**Paper I
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Both schools defend intrinsic validity but disagree about how cognition is known and how illusion occurs. These differences produce many recent applied PYQs.

KEY DATA

Issue	Prabhakara	Bhatta
Cognition known	Triputi-pratyaksa: cognition reveals knower, known, and itself together.	Jnatrta / inferred or subsequently known cognition through manifested objecthood.
Error	Akhyati: failure to discriminate present perception from memory.	Viparita-khyati: positive misapprehension of one thing as another.
Validity	Intrinsic; cognition is self-revealing in a threefold act.	Intrinsic; validity belongs to cognition before defeat.
Word meaning	Words convey connected meanings through anvitaabhidhana.	Words first convey individual meanings, then combine: abhihitavaya.
Absence	No independent anupalabdhī.	Anupalabdhī independently reveals abhava.

SHELL-SILVER ERROR**STATIC THEORY**

- **Intrinsic validity does not imply infallibility:** a cognition is accepted unless defeated by defect or contradiction.
- **How do I know that I know?:** Prabhakara stresses self-revelation; Bhatta explains awareness of cognition through its effect or knower-status.
- **Language debate:** sentence meaning is either directly conveyed as connected or constructed after separately expressed word meanings.
- **Nyaya contrast:** validity is externally established through successful action and correspondence.

MEMORY HOOK

PRA-BHA: Prabhakara = connection already in word-use; Bhatta = expressed meanings assembled.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Akhyati treats error as non-discrimination, not total absence of cognition.
2. Viparita-khyati admits a positive erroneous identification.
3. Intrinsic validity concerns cognition's initial authority, not immunity from later defeat.

MAINS ANGLE

The sub-schools agree on epistemic trust but differ over the phenomenology of knowing, error, and linguistic unity.

STUDY LINK

Use a side-by-side grid for all Bhatta-Prabhakara questions.

HIGH**Vedic Testimony and Strongest Criticism-Defence**

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Mimamsa treats Vedic words and their relation to meanings as beginningless and authorless. This removes human defect and grounds injunctions about supersensible duty.

KEY DATA

Issue	Criticism	Mimamsa Defence / Qualification
Intrinsic validity	False cognitions also initially appear valid.	Invalidity is a later externally caused defeat; immediate trust is pragmatically unavoidable.
Apauruseya Veda	A text without author seems historically implausible.	The claim concerns beginningless linguistic revelation and freedom from authorial defect.
Arthapatti	Nyaya reduces it to inference.	Postulation is triggered by explanatory incompatibility, not remembered vyapti.
Anupalabdhi	Non-perception is merely a negative condition for inference.	Absence is directly known when an eligible object is not apprehended.
Apurva	An unseen potency is ad hoc.	It explains delayed ritual result without an arbitrary divine distributor.
Action-centered Veda	Descriptive or contemplative passages seem secondary.	Mimamsa interprets them in relation to injunction and ritual purpose.

FROM VEDIC SENTENCE TO RITUAL FRUIT



COMPARISON TABLE

Issue	Mimamsa	Contrast
Validity	Intrinsic	Nyaya: extrinsic
Veda	Authorless	Nyaya: omniscient divine author
Absence	Bhatta anupalabdhī	Nyaya: perception/inference accounts
Error	Akhyati or viparita-khyati	Advaita: anirvacaniya appearance

MAINS ANGLE

Mimamsa epistemology is systematic, but critics question whether its special pramanas and authorless scripture are independent discoveries or devices serving ritual authority.

STUDY LINK

In critical answers, distinguish epistemic economy from theological or ritual motivation.

HIGH

PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

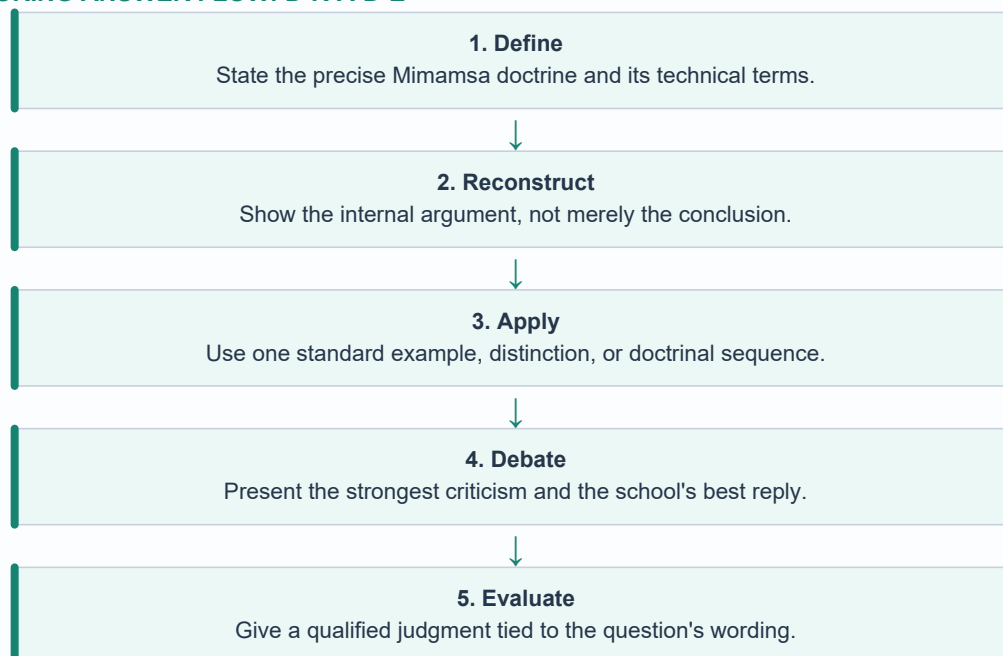
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 15	Arthapatti as independent against Nyaya reduction.	Explanatory necessity versus vyapti inference.
2022 / 20	Why Prabhakara and Kumarila differ on error despite intrinsic validity.	Akhyati versus viparita-khyati.
2023 / 15	Bhatta anupalabdhi.	Eligibility, non-apprehension, absence.
2024 / 20	How do I know that I know? Nyaya, Bhatta, Prabhakara.	Cognition of cognition and validity.
2024 / 15	Applied candidate success: Bhatta and Nyaya.	Arthapatti versus inference.
2025 / 15	Bhatta-Prabhakara debate on abhava and knowledge.	Ontology and pramana.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** identify the sub-school, define the doctrine, give the standard example, contrast Nyaya.
- **15 marks:** reconstruct the cognitive mechanism, defend independence, present the reduction objection, and judge.
- **20 marks:** compare both Mimamsa schools and Nyaya on validity, self-awareness, error, language, or absence with an applied illustration.
- **Applied drill:** A healthy student who does not eat is gaining weight. Show how arthapatti yields an unseen explanatory fact and why Nyaya calls it inference.
- **Applied drill:** Compare Bhatta anupalabdhi and Nyaya inference in knowing that a book is absent from a well-lit table.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Intrinsic validity means no cognition is ever false.
- CORRECT:** Cognitions are prima facie valid but may be defeated. Avoid infallibilism.
- WRONG:** Both schools accept six pramanas.
- CORRECT:** Prabhakara accepts five; Bhatta adds anupalabdhi. Basic distinction.
- WRONG:** Arthapatti is a guess.
- CORRECT:** It is a compelled explanatory postulation. Show its logic.
- WRONG:** Mimamsa proves Veda through God.
- CORRECT:** It emphasizes authorlessness and rejects dependence on a divine author. Key contrast.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
Intrinsic validity means no cognition is ever false.	Cognitions are prima facie valid but may be defeated.	Avoid infallibilism.
Both schools accept six pramanas.	Prabhakara accepts five; Bhatta adds anupalabdhi.	Basic distinction.
Arthapatti is a guess.	It is a compelled explanatory postulation.	Show its logic.
Mimamsa proves Veda through God.	It emphasizes authorlessness and rejects dependence on a divine author.	Key contrast.

MAINS ANGLE

Mimamsa develops a sophisticated default-trust epistemology; its exam value lies in testing whether postulation, absence, and self-revealing cognition are genuinely irreducible.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.